ICT for development
and social good
Master program

Research and fieldwork in International Cooperation

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Module Aims: Research & Fieldwork in International Cooperation

This module aims to:

1. Reflect on **what research means** in international cooperation
2. Explore **why and how research matters** in development practice
3. Provide tools to **design a research proposal**
4. Support you in developing the **Final Project o the Master**

What kind of “research” is required by the Master

- From the **Final Project Guidelines**, it is very clear that the Final Project is **NOT**:
- a traditional academic thesis
- a descriptive report of the internship
- a purely theoretical research work

➡ Instead, it is an **applied research or development**, with the following features:

- ✓ **Research-in-practice**
- It **emerges from the internship**
- It uses the field as a space for:
  - observation
  - experimentation
  - learning from failure
- It integrates **theory and practice**

✓ **Dual structure**

- Light theoretical concept

Not a long literature review

A *conceptual framework* that:

explains the problem

justifies the chosen approach

connects ICT and development

- Practical component

A prototype

A methodological framework

A re-appropriation of an ICT tool

A practical output usable by an organization

✓ **Change-oriented**

Focused on **social good**

Embedded in **international cooperation**

Impact-driven (even small or local impact is valid)

How “Research & Fieldwork” Connects to the Final Project

Doing research in International Cooperation means:

1. Starting from a **real-world problem**, not from a theory
2. Letting the **field shape your research question**
3. Collecting **feasible data**, not “ideal” data
4. Turning observations into **structured knowledge**
5. Connecting **ICT, theory, and practice** in a meaningful way

The Final Project is the **formalisation** of this process.

Research and development: what relationship?

CONTRIBUTING TO PROCESSES OF CHANGE

DEVELOPMENT WORK USUALLY AIMS TO CREATE **SOCIAL CHANGE** OF SOME SORT.

THERE ARE MANY THEORIES OF HOW SOCIAL CHANGE TAKES PLACE, AND ON TOP OF THESE MANY MORE THEORIES ABOUT HOW DEVELOPMENT WORKERS CAN AND SHOULD INTERVENE IN THESE PROCESSES.

ONE WAY OF THINKING ABOUT THE USE OF RESEARCH-TYPE ACTIVITIES WITHIN DEVELOPMENT WORK IS TO FOCUS ON ***HOW RESEARCH CAN CONTRIBUTE TOWARDS PROCESSES OF CHANGE.***

UNDERSTANDING

(PEOPLE, CONTEXTS, PROBLEMS,..)

RELATIONALLY

Research is ***integral*** to development policy and practice

Research is used **THROUGHOUT** the development process:

- from baseline or feasibility studies and pilot projects
- through ethnographic studies of communities or contexts to inform understanding and policy
- to monitoring and evalutation strategies to ensure the effectiveness of development policies and practices

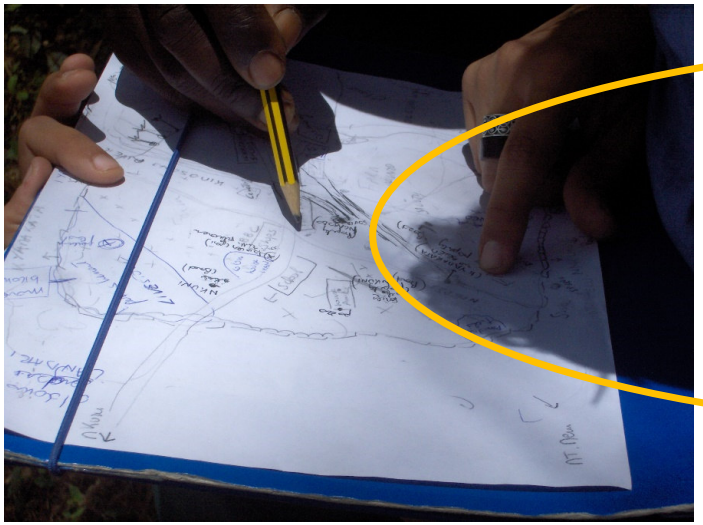
Let’s reflect together… 5 minutes

The «Health for everyone» project aims at building a health centre in the Maasai community of Mkuru, Tanzania

How can research allow a better understanding of the context, project, people?

In what phase/phases of the project?

What can be achieved through using research in development work?



Gaining information

Let's try to see **what** can be achieved through research, through some real-life examples.

Research is essential to:

guarantee a **correct understanding o problems** and consequently of the possible answers

Why were children missing school? Northern Iraq

*Save the Children was concerned about low school attendance within a Kurdish community in Northern Iraq. The organization had assumed that the cause of the problem would be the **parents' lack of money**. However when researchers talked with the children, they found out that **teachers were beating the children** so severely that they were afraid to go to school. There were also allegations of sexual abuse. Save the Children was then able to discuss with the local authorities a program of teacher training which addresses how children should be treated as well as how to convey information.*

(Source: Laws et al., 2013)

Research is essential to:

- Research is also important simply in ensuring that development programs are **appropriate to the needs** they aim to address (and not harmful…).

Appropriate aid for nomads in Somaliland

*A failure to read ethnography in the immediate post-conflict phase on Somaliland led agencies to **build schools in pastoral nomadic communities** that would normally move continuously with their herds to water sources. Schools created a focal point for settlement, but also provided a **target for grenades** and by bringing people together rendered them more vulnerable to attack.*

- New research/greater use of **existing research** (especially in emergency situations, there is often a failure to seek out relevant research on a group suffering a crisis – for example work produced by geographers, sociologists and anthropologists – and this can compromise effective intervention)

(Source: Laws et al., 2013)

Qualitative and Quantitative

- The major divide in research approaches is sometimes presented as between quantitative and qualitative research.

- As can be read from the words used, the first is seen as concerned with **numbers** and the second more with **meanings**.
  - A quantitative approach asks how many people share a particular characteristic, or hold a particular view.
  - A qualitative one looks more at what people think and feel, and why.

- However it is not usually helpful to debate the virtues of one approach against the other. **Most research for practical purposes contains some element of both**, and this is how it should be.

Data collection	Quantitative research	Qualitative research
Research design	Structured, precedes completely the research	Open, it can be redesigned during research
Representativeness	Representative sample, results extendible with statistical techniques	Variable, non standardized, results extendible with argumentative techniques
Data collection instrument	Standard, uniform	Harmonized to context
Nature o data	Standardized, numbers	In-depth, text

Source: Corbetta, P., 2015, p. 61.

EXERCISE

To reflect on how these different approaches affect research processes, let us take the case of a development worker who wants to commission a study of the situation of children in a longstanding refugee camp.

A quantitative approach would…

A qualitative (constructivist) approach would…

A quantitative approach…

- might **weigh** and **measure** children and would be likely to use well-tested **questionnaires** or checklists to see how the children are faring in relation to standard measures of child development.
- These would include standards for **psychological adjustment**, social behaviour, **educational achievement** etc. They might interview **parents** and/or those who work with the children, looking for evidence of maladjustment, on standard indicators.
- They would want to know how many children go to school, how many suffer from physical or mental illness, how many commit offences, how many teenage pregnancies occur.
- These are measures of quality of life which are pre-defined by other (powerful) people who are removed from the particular situation. Teenage pregnancy is one example of a measure which is widely taken in the North to be obviously a 'bad thing', but where the young women involved may not agree that it is a problem (Phoenix, 1991).

(Source: Laws et al., 2013)

A qualitative approach…

- A ‘social constructionist’ researcher might instead **spend time in the camp** getting to know the people and observing the situation. Whilst they might seek broad information about indicators of health and welfare, they would concentrate on what the children themselves and their parents think about their situation.
- They would ask **open questions** about what children and adults consider to be the benefits and drawbacks of life in the refugee camp for children.
- Keen to avoid making assumptions, they might not take it as given that life in the camp is worse for the children than the place they came from but would ask questions about this.
- Aware of power dynamics, they would try a variety of ways to **enable children** (and **mothers**) in particular **to voice** their point of view, away from the ‘community leaders’ as well as the camp authorities.

(Source: Laws et al., 2013)

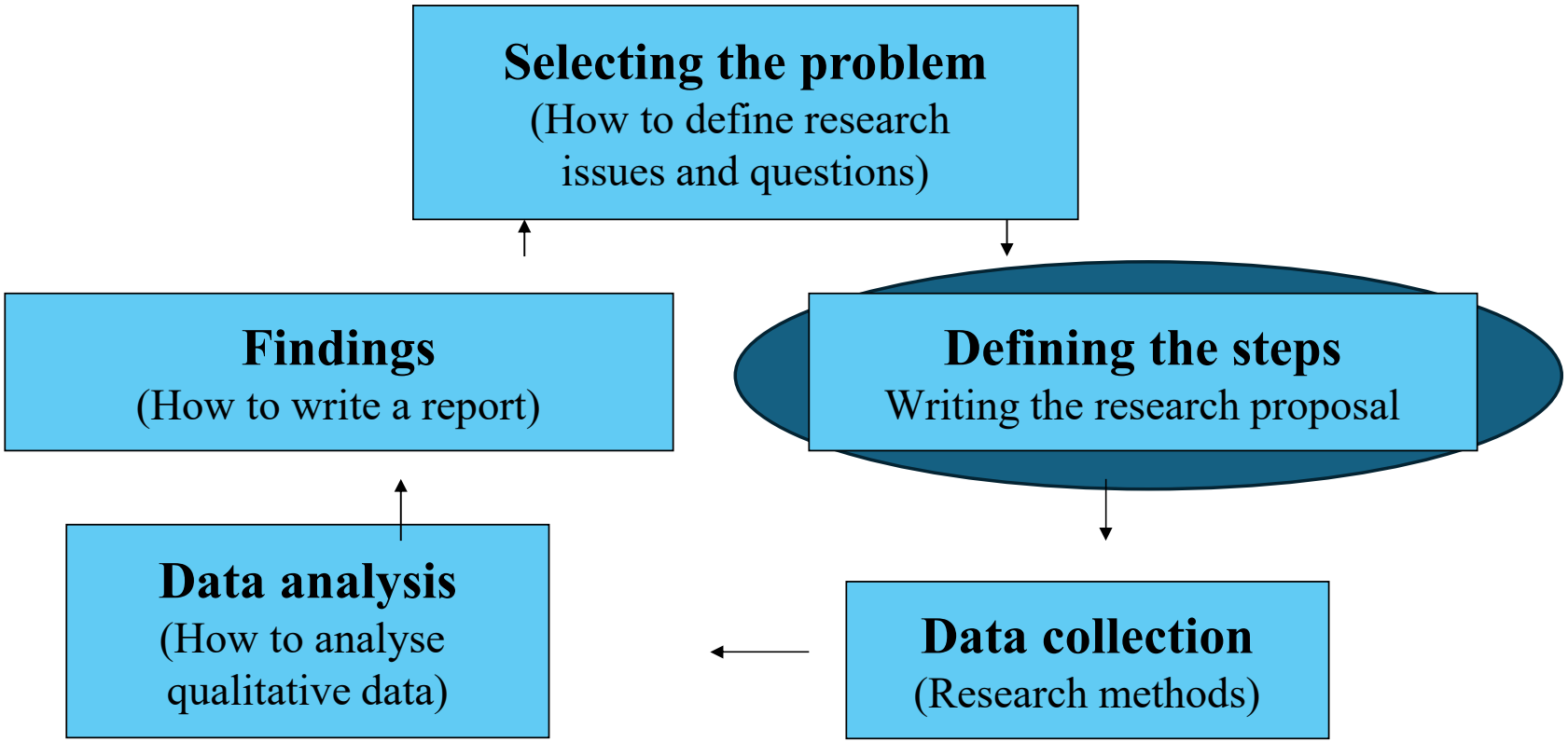
RESEARCH CHOISES

Which approaches are chosen depends upon many things.

This may be a tactical choice, depending upon the issue in question and the kind of change which is desired – whether it be, for example, legal, economic, or a change of ordinary people's attitudes.

But this choice also springs from professionals' own beliefs about how change takes place. Some place their faith in parliamentary processes, others in grass-roots education and action.

Developing a research project: main steps



Source: Bailey, 1995

From curiosity to research design (and back again)

- What **TOPIC (Issue/area of study)**? What do I want to know? Why?
- What Research **QUESTION**?
- What **METHODOLOGY**? Reflects Research orientation and knowledge assumptions (ontologies and epistemologies)?
- What **METHODS** of Data Collection/Generation? What type of data would best answer my question?
- **WHERE**, **WHO**, **HOW MANY**? How to **ACCESS**? Practical, organizational? Timetable/budget
- **ETHICAL REVIEW** How will you mitigate/navigate risks and dilemmas?
- How to **ANALYSE** ? Conceptual lens? Analyzing data to answer RQ
- How to **CONCLUDE, WRITE UP, AND PRESENT**?

! Not actually as linear as often presented

Example: From Field Experience to a Research Project (ICT4D)

- **Context:**
  Use of a mobile data collection platform by a local NGO in a rural development project

- **Research focus:**
  Understanding how digital tools are adopted and adapted in low-resource contexts

- **Outcome:**
  A research-informed proposal to improve the use of ICT in the project

1 TOPIC – What issue or area of study?

The broad topic is **ICT adoption in development projects**.

More specifically:

- the use of a **mobile data collection plat?orm**
- in a **rural development project**
- implemented by a **local NGO**

At this stage, we are not yet doing research — we are identifying a **relevant and situated area o?concern**.

2 What do I want to know? Why?

During the internship, several issues emerge:

- field staff do not always use the platform as intended
- data quality is inconsistent
- paper-based practices persist alongside digital tools

The “why”:

- the NGO relies on this data for reporting and decision-making
- poor data quality affects programme design
- the ICT tool is assumed to “work”, but its use is not questioned

This turns a practical issue into a **researchable problem**.

3 RESEARCH QUESTION

A possible research question could be:

- *How do field staff perceive, adapt, and use a mobile data collection platform in their daily work, and how does this affect data quality and project implementation?*

This question:

- is context-specific
- is focused on practices and meanings
- connects ICT use to development outcomes

4 METHODOLOGY – Research orientation and assumptions

The research adopts a **qualitative, interpretive methodology**.

Underlying assumptions:

- technology use is socially constructed
- knowledge is produced through interaction with users
- understanding practices is more relevant than measuring performance

This methodological choice reflects:

- the nature of the research question
- the development context
- the limited availability of quantitative data

5 METHODS – Data collection / generation

To answer the research question, the following methods are selected:

- semi-structured interviews with field staff
- informal observation during data collection activities
- analysis of project documents and digital forms

The data generated is mainly:

- qualitative
- contextual
- experiential

This type of data is the most appropriate to understand *how and why* the ICT tool is used.

6 WHERE, WHO, HOW MANY? Access and feasibility

- **Where:** two rural project sites
- **Who:** 8–10 field officers and one project coordinator
- **Access:** facilitated through the internship and NGO supervision
- Constraints considered:
  - limited time in the field
  - travel costs
  - staff availability
- The research design is adjusted to what is **realistically feasible**.

7 ETHICAL REVIEW – Risks and dilemmas

Potential ethical issues include:

- power relations between researcher and staff
- fear of evaluation or judgement
- confidentiality of internal data

Mitigation strategies:

- informed consent
- anonymisation of participants
- clear communication that the research is not an audit

Ethics is treated as an **ongoing responsibility**, not a one-time approval.

8 ANALYSIS – Making sense of the data

The data is analysed using a **conceptual lens** drawn from:

- ICT4D literature on technology appropriation
- concepts such as usability, ownership, and context adaptation

Analysis focuses on:
- recurring themes
- mismatches between design and practice
- informal workarounds

This is where field experiences become **structured knowledge**.

9 CONCLUSIONS, WRITE-UP, AND PRESENTATION

The research leads to:

- a clearer understanding of why the tool is not used as expected
- identification of organisational and contextual barriers

For the Final Project:

- the **theoretical component** explains the findings
- the **practical component** proposes:
  - a revised data collection workflow
  - training recommendations
  - minor adaptations to the ICT tool

- The final presentation communicates:
  - the problem
  - the research process
  - the proposed solution

From Field-Based Research to Literature Review

Why do a literature review in ICT for Development?

- To **situate your field experience** within existing knowledge
- To **make sense of what you observe** in the field
- To **build your theoretical concept**
- To **justify your research choices**
- To strengthen the **Final Project**

➡ Literature does not replace fieldwork — it **dialogues with it**

1 Literature review starts *after* (and before) the field

In many textbooks, literature review is presented as the *first step* of research.

In international cooperation, it often works differently:

- you observe something in the field
- you encounter a problem or tension
- then you turn to literature to understand it better

This is not a weakness — it is **normal and legitimate**.

2 Linking to the example we just saw

In our example:

- field staff adapt the mobile data collection platform
- paper practices coexist with digital tools
- data quality issues persist

The literature review helps us ask:

- Have others observed similar issues?
- How is ICT adoption explained in development contexts?
- What concepts help interpret these practices?

Literature becomes a **lens**, not a recipe.

3 What kind of literature is relevant in ICT4D?

For this type of research, relevant literature may include:

- ICT for Development studies
- digital inclusion and technology appropriation
- information systems in low-resource settings
- participatory and user-centred design
- critical development studies

You are not expected to read *everything* — you are expected to read **strategically**.

4 What does the literature review do for your project?

A good literature review allows you to:

- frame your research problem more clearly
- refine your research question
- choose a coherent methodology
- select appropriate methods
- define your conceptual lens

In the Final Project, this becomes the **"light theoretical concept"**.

5 How to actually *do* the literature review

Practically, doing a literature review means:

- identifying key themes and debates
- comparing different perspectives
- linking concepts to your field observations

It is **not**:

- a summary of articles
- a list of authors
- a demonstration of how much you read

The goal is understanding, not accumulation.

6 Writing the literature review for the Final Project

When writing:

- start from your research problem
- introduce the key concepts you need
- show how literature helps interpret your case
- keep it concise and focused

Remember: the Final Project requires a **"light" theoretical concept**, not a full academic review.

In this Master:

- fieldwork raises questions
- literature helps you interpret them
- research connects the two

If your literature review helps explain what you saw in the field, you are doing it right.

Tips for locating the literature…

- Find and study carefully any **recent reviews** of the 'state of the art' in the field you are working in. These may be found in official documents, or academic publications (a couple of "good articles" can make the difference)
- Look '**sideways**' from your central subjects. Don't confine yourself to searching within one discipline (eg anthropology, geography, development, etc.) – there may be relevant data in a number of fields, and you may need to specifically seek them out, as cross-referencing can be weak
- **Ask people**!
- Use the **Internet** when you have ideas about where to look for information – specific sites, or specialist databases
- Google scholar: searching for academic publications

Locating relevant documents

- One of the worries about undertaking a literature review is that you might **get lost** for weeks, wandering amongst a lot of **not-very-relevant material**.
- It is important to **scan** possibly useful books and articles rather than settle down to read every word.
- Keep a **clear focus** on the information you need to find.
- Break down your ‘big questions’ into **sub-questions**, and search for evidence relating to these.
- **Refer back to the research focus**, the research questions, and the broad aims and objectives of your study at regular intervals to help you to find your way through the material you come across.
- You need to identify a number of **key words** which you can use in searching for relevant material.
- Much important material may be **unpublished** – you need to **ask people** what exists, and seek it out.
- Make guesses about what ‘ought’ to be available, and see if you can find it. **Be persistent**.

Five-minute reading

Record	Record author, title, and publisher
Look	Look at organisation/structure, preface/introduction/blurb, diagrams/pictures
Scan	Quickly scan read introduction and concluding chapter or abstract/summary
Focus on	From contents focus on most relevant – read key points highlighted in first or last paragraphs at beginning and end of chapters
Use	Use sub-headings to go through book - scan for ideas, or look for specific points in index.

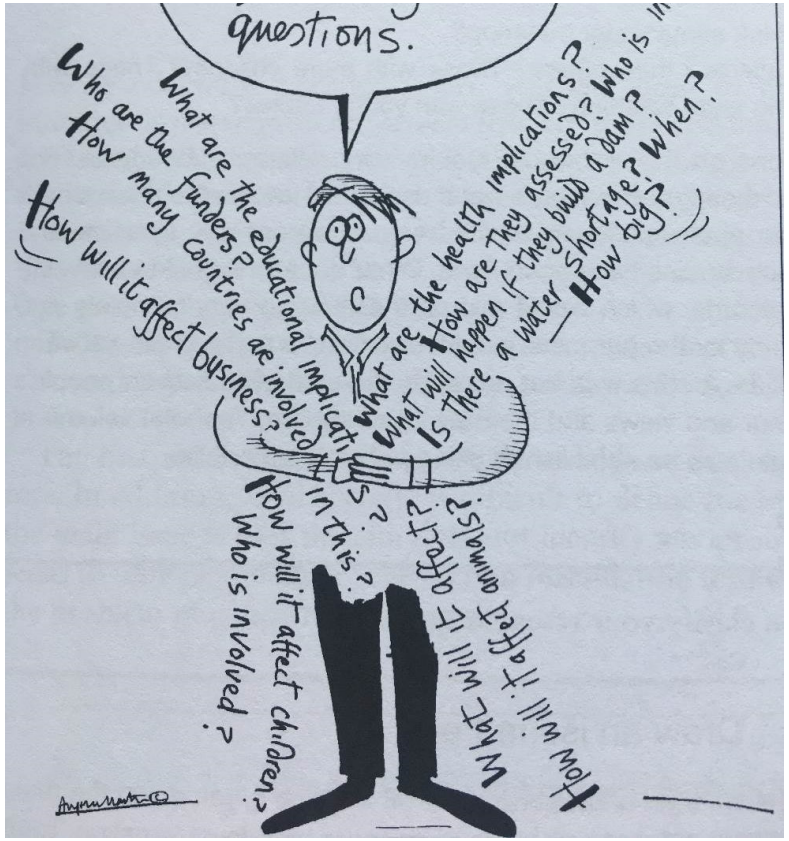
Setting the research questions

- Once you are clear on the general focus of the research, the next important task is to identify the key questions to be asked by the research.

- These need to be **researchable questions** and capable of **being answered by methods** which are feasible for you to use.

- It may be worth making a **'long list'** of all the questions you would ideally like answered, before **narrowing it down** to the questions you will be able to address in this project.

- **Beware** of trying to answer **too many** questions



Identifying Researchable Questions

Example topic:

Use of a mobile data collection platform in a rural development project

Step 1 – Long list o possible questions
Step 2 – What is easible to research?
Step 3 – Focused research question(s)

Good research is about **making choices**, not answering everything

Step 1 Creating a “long list” of questions

When you start from field experience, you often have **many questions at once**.

For example, in a project using a mobile data collection platform, you might want to ask:

•Why was this platform chosen by the NGO?
•Is the platform technically appropriate for the local context?
•Do field staff have sufficient digital skills?
•How reliable is the collected data?
•How do connectivity issues affect usage?
•How do power relations influence who uses the tool?
•How do beneficiaries perceive data collection?
•Does the platform improve decision-making?
•Is the tool sustainable in the long term?

This is a *very good starting point* — curiosity is not the problem.

Step 2 Checking feasibility and researchability

Now we ask a different set of questions:
•Do I have **access** to the people involved?
•Do I have **time** to collect this data?
•Do I have the **skills** to analyse it?
•Can these questions be answered with **qualitative methods**?

Would answering all of them be realistic in one project?

For example:
•Evaluating long-term sustainability may require years of data
•Measuring impact on decision-making may require organisational data you cannot access
•Beneficiaries’ perceptions may require ethical clearance and translation

This step is about **designing within constraints**.

Step 3 Narrowing down to researchable questions

After considering feasibility, you may narrow the focus. Instead of many questions, you might settle on **one main research question**, supported by a few sub-questions.

Example main research question:
How do field staff use and adapt a mobile data collection platform in their daily work within a rural development project?

Supporting sub-questions:

- What challenges do field staff encounter when using the platform?
- What informal practices or workarounds emerge?
- How do organisational expectations shape platform use?

These questions:

- are researchable
- can be answered through interviews and observation
- fit the time and access constraints
- focus on *use and practice*, not everything at once

Why fewer questions are better

Trying to answer too many questions leads to:

- superficial analysis
- weak conclusions
- poorly integrated Final Projects

A focused research question allows you to:

- go deeper
- produce clearer insights
- link findings to theory and ICT design

A strong research project is not about answering all possible questions.

It is about:

- identifying what matters most
- choosing what is feasible
- being explicit about what you cannot answer

Research question generator

Goal - what do you want to do?	To discover, describe, explore, identify, illustrate, understand, explain, change
What is the specific topic/issue?	Phenomenon, situation, culture, process, event
What is the fieldwork context and who are you interested in?	Specific location (Sites/settings) and Participants (cultures, organisations, groups)
What is nature of question?	What, who, where, when, how or why?
Studying ?	Opinions/perspectives, meanings, cultures, influences, associations, enablers, barriers, effects, relationships, processes
Can use to form research purpose or research question	

Source: Jackie Shaw, 2021

Example - Research question generation

Goal - what do you want to do?	**To explain**
What is the specific topic/issue?	Mental health stigma and health seeking behaviour
What is the fieldwork context and who are you interested in?	Accra, Ghana Teens in a low income neighbourhood
What is nature of question?	how
Interested in Studying ?	influences
How does mental health stigma influence health seeking behaviour among teens in a low income neighbourhood in Accra, Ghana	

Source: Jackie Shaw, 2021

What is a Research Timetable (and why it matters)

- A research timetable is a **planning tool** that shows:

  - What activities you will carry out
  - When they will happen
  - In what order
  - Within your real constraints

A timetable helps make your research **feasible, realistic, and credible**

Example: Use of a mobile data collection platform by a local NGO in a rural development project

Phase	Activity	Timeframe
1	Initial observations & problem framing	Weeks 1–2
2	Literature review & concept refinement	Weeks 2–4
3	Research design & tools preparation	Week 4
4	Data collection (interviews & observation)	Weeks 5–6
5	Data analysis	Weeks 7–8
6	Writing & practical output development	Weeks 9–10
7	Final review & presentation preparation	Week 11

Timetable – an example

Table 8.2 Research planning timetable

	Jan	Feb	Mar	April	May	June	July	Aug	Sept	Oct	Nov	Dec	Jan
Planning, discussion with partners	→	→											
Search for existing information	→	→											
Draft research tools (questionnaires etc)		→	→										
Select and contact respondents		→	→	→	→								
Pilot tools and revise		→	→	→									
Fieldwork 1. Focus groups				→	→								
Fieldwork 2. Interviews						→	→	→					
Transcribing					→	→		→	→				
Analysis						→		→	→	→	→		
Writing										→	→	→	
Editing and publication											→	→	
Dissemination												→	→

Final Project:
Aims, Expectations, and What Is Required

The Final Project aims to:

- Apply **theoretical and practical knowledge** to real-world ICT4D contexts
- Integrate **ICT tools, platforms, and concepts** in international cooperation
- Produce **concrete value** for organisations and communities
- Communicate results to a **wider public audience**

Your Final Project should:

- Be closely connected to your **internship**
- Combine **theory + practice**
- Reflect a **social good** perspective
- Result in:
  - a *light theoretical concept*
  - a *practical output*

Final Project – Theoretical Framework: What You Are Expected to Do

- The theoretical framework is where you:

  - **Frame your project academically and pro essionally**
  - Explain **why your project matters**
  - Show **how you did research**
  - Connect ieldwork, ICT, and Master learnings
  - Analyse and reflect on your inal results

*It is not a report of activities, but an **analytical research narrative***

1. TITLE

The title should:

•clearly reflect the **topic and focus** of your project

•hint at the **ICT4D dimension**

•be specific, not generic

A good title already tells the reader:

•*what the project is about*

•*in which context*

Avoid vague titles like *"ICT and Development Project"*.

2. FIELD

This is where you locate your project sectorally.

Examples:

•health

•education

•humanitarian action

•human rights

•governance

•environmental sustainability

This helps the Commission understand:

•the **policy and practice domain** you are working in

•how your project fits within development debates

3. INTERNSHIP (max 150 words)

This section provides **context**, not description.

You should:

•briefly introduce the organisation

•explain where it operates

•clarify what type of work it does

You should **not**:

•list all your tasks

•describe daily activities

The internship is presented as the **research setting** of your project.

4. ABSTRACT (max 150 words)

The abstract is a **compact overview o the entire project**.

It should include:

•the topic

•the approach or methods

•the type of results or output

Write it **last**, even though it appears at the beginning.

Think of it as:

"If someone reads only this, do they understand what I did and why?"

5. INTRODUCTION AND MAIN QUESTIONS (max 300 words)
This section sets the scene.
You should:
•describe the **context and problem**
•explain why the topic matters for:

- international cooperation
- social good
- ICT4D

You also need to:
•explain the **structure** of the Final Project
•clearly state your **main research question(s)**
This is where you show **clarity o□□ocus**.

6. OBJECTIVES
Objectives answer the question:
What does this project aim to achieve?
They should be:
•clear
•realistic
•aligned with your research question
You may include:
•one main objective
•a few specific objectives
Avoid objectives that are too broad or unmeasurable.

7. METHODOLOGY AND RESEARCH METHODS (max 500 words)

This is a **core research section**.
Here you explain:

- your methodological approach (e.g. qualitative, interpretive)
- your research methods (e.g. interviews, observation, desk research)

You should discuss:

- what data you worked with
- how it was generated or collected
- strengths and limitations of your approach

This section shows that:

- your research choices were **intentional and justified**.

9. DISCUSSION OF THE IMPLICATION OF THE MASTER PROGRAMME (max 500 words)

This section answers:
How did the Master shape this project?

You should explicitly mention:

- ICT tools or platforms used
- theories, frameworks, or concepts from the Master
- methods or principles learned during the course

This is where you show:

- integration of learning
- critical application of knowledge
- Evidence-based reasoning is key.

9. DISCUSSION OF FINAL RESULTS / PRODUCT / FINDINGS (max 800 words)

This is the **analytical core** of the project.

You should:

- present your findings OR analyse your final product
- explain what worked and what didn't
- critically reflect on limitations

This is not a success story — it is a **critical discussion**.

The Commission is interested in:

- reasoning
- learning
- analytical depth

10. CONCLUSIONS (max 300 words)

The conclusions should:

- directly respond to your research question
- summarise key insights
- highlight implications for ICT4D practice

Do not introduce new information here.

Think of conclusions as:

"What do we now understand better because of this project?"

Remember…

The theoretical framework is not about writing *more*.

It is about writing **clearly, critically, and coherently**.

If every section helps the reader understand your research journey, you are doing it right.

Group Exercise: Researching ICT in Everyday Life (30 minutes)

Work in groups of 3

Choose **ONE everyday ICT experience** you are familiar with and use it to build a **mini RESEARCH PROPOSAL**.

Possible topics (experience-based)

1 Accessing public services online
Think about:

- booking healthcare appointments
- applying for permits, visas, or benefits
- accessing university or municipal platforms

👉 Who is included/excluded? What barriers exist?

2 Moving around the city with digital tools
Think about:

- transport apps
- digital tickets
- navigation and mapping apps

👉 Who benefits? Who struggles? What happens when digital access fails?

3 Platform work and digital labour
Think about:
delivery or ride-hailing apps
online freelancing platforms
algorithmic task assignment
👉 How do platforms shape working conditions and power relations?

4 Access to information and visibility online
Think about:
social media feeds
news platforms
language or accessibility barriers
👉 Whose voices are visible? Who is marginalised or misrepresented?

5 Data collection and surveillance in daily life
Think about:
cameras in public spaces
tracking apps
data collected by platforms you use
👉 Who controls the data? Who is monitored? Who decides?

Your task (30-40 minutes)

- Using your chosen experience, define:
  - Topic & field
  - Context and problem
  - One main research question
  - 2–3 objectives
  - Methodology & methods
  - ICT tools or concepts
  - Expected findings or outputs

*Keep it **simple, concrete, and feasible***

Model Mini Theoretical Framework
ICT, Mobility, and Social Inequality in the City

1 Topic & Field

Topic: Use of digital mobility tools in urban public transportation
Field: Urban development, mobility, and social inclusion

2 Context and Problem

- In many cities, access to public transportation increasingly relies on digital tools such as mobile ticketing apps, QR codes, and real-time navigation platforms. While these technologies are promoted as efficient and user-friendly, they may unintentionally exclude certain groups, such as elderly people, migrants, low-income residents, or individuals with limited digital skills or access to smartphones.
  The shift toward digital-only mobility systems raises questions about equity, accessibility, and the right to the city, particularly when alternative non-digital options are reduced or removed.

3 Main Research Question

- *How do digital public transport tools shape access to mobility for different groups in the city, and what barriers emerge for digitally excluded users?*

4 Objectives

- To explore how different users experience digital public transport systems
- To identify barriers related to access, skills, language, or affordability
- To analyse the implications of digital mobility tools for urban social inclusion

5 Methodology and Methods

The study adopts a **qualitative, interpretive approach**, focusing on users' experiences and perceptions.
Methods include:

- semi-structured interviews with public transport users
- short observations in transport hubs (e.g. ticket machines, bus stops)
- desk research on local mobility policies and digitalisation strategies

6 ICT Tools and Concepts

The project focuses on:

- mobile ticketing applications
- real-time transport information platforms

Key concepts include:

- digital divide
- accessibility
- right to the city
- technology appropriation

7 Expected Findings / Output

The research is expected to show that:

- digital mobility tools benefit users with high digital literacy
- some users rely on informal workarounds or assistance
- digital-only systems can deepen existing inequalities

The practical output could be:

- a set of design recommendations for more inclusive mobility services
- a framework to assess digital accessibility in urban transport systems

This framework:

- ❑ starts from everyday experience
- ❑ defines a clear, researchable question
- ❑ matches methods to the question
- ❑ links ICT to social justice
- ❑ leads to a realistic, applied output

This is the same logic you will use for your Final Project — just expanded and supported by research.

EACH GROUP - 5 MINUTES

- TO PRESENT RESEARCH PROPOSAL
- TO SHARE STRENGHTS AND CHALLENGES OF GROUP WORK
- EACH GROUP COMMENTS ON OTHER GROUPS RESEARCH PROPOSALS